

Analysing Quotations in Jekyll and Hyde

Methods, Context, and Effective Writing — a guide for GCSE English Literature students tackling Robert Louis Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde*.





Why Quote Analysis Matters

Quotations are your evidence

They prove your argument. Without them, claims about Stevenson's writing are just opinion.

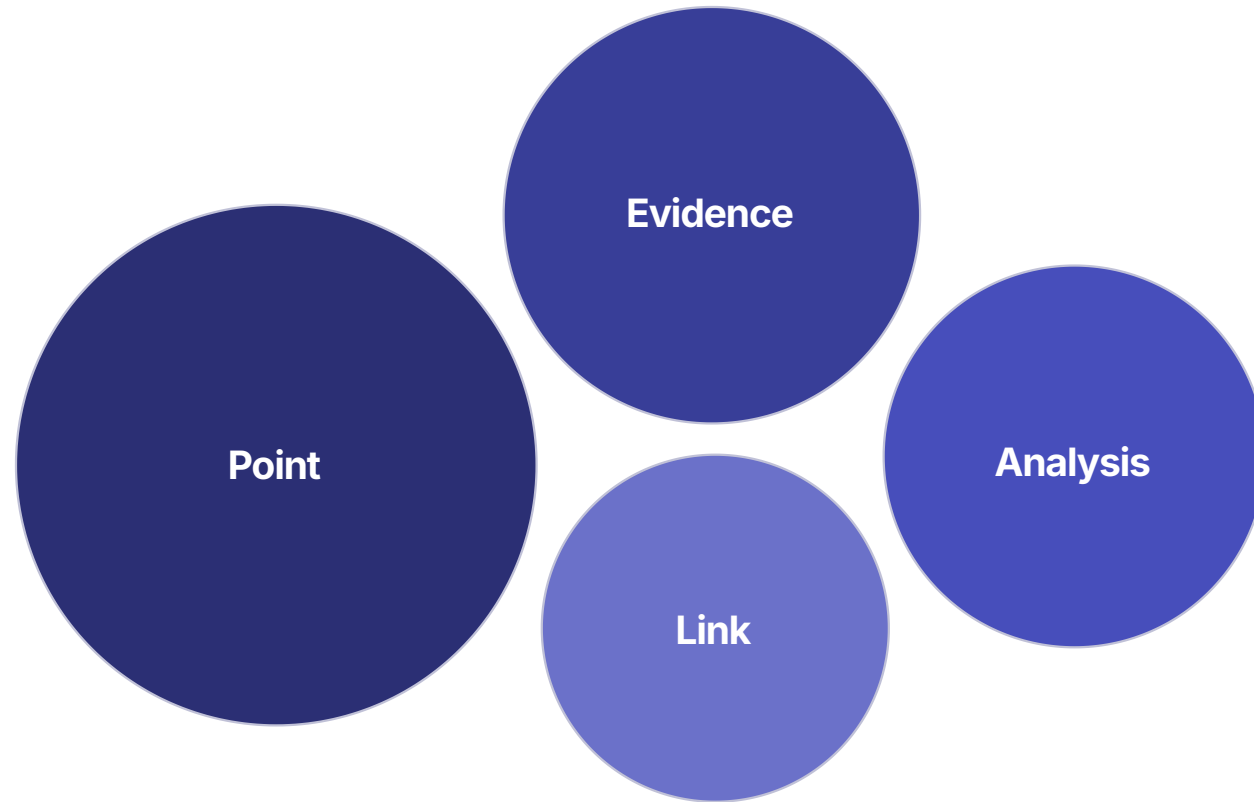
Analysis is your argument

Strong analysis goes beyond *what* a quote says — it explores *how* and *why* language creates meaning.

Examiners reward depth

Top marks go to answers that explore language, structure, form, and context working *together* — not separately.

Methods for Analysing Quotations



The PEAL/PETAL structure gives every analytical paragraph a clear, logical shape that examiners can follow easily.

Key Analytical Techniques

- **Zoom in on individual words:** connotations, word class, etymology
- **Sentence structure:** short sentences for tension, dashes for interruption, lists for chaos
- **Literary devices:** imagery, symbolism, pathetic fallacy, gothic motifs, duality
- **Narrative perspective:** multiple unreliable narrators — Utterson, Lanyon, Jekyll's confession
- **Alternative interpretations:** "The writer could also suggest..." shows flexibility of meaning

Key Quotations to Analyse

These quotations are central to the novel's key themes. Each rewards close, layered analysis.

1

"Hyde was pale and dwarfish"

Physical degeneration — links to Victorian pseudo-science: physiognomy and the idea that inner evil shows on the body.

2

"Something downright detestable"

Vague, unsettling language creates an *indescribability* around Hyde — he defies rational articulation, mirroring Victorian repression.

3

"Man is not truly one, but truly two"

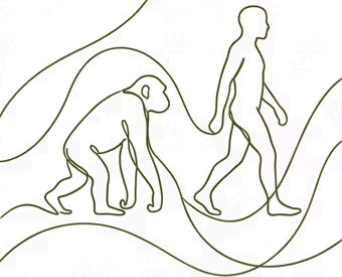
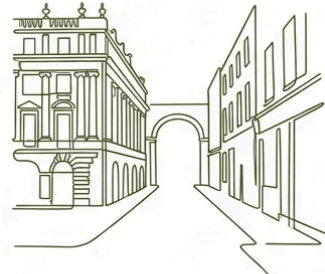
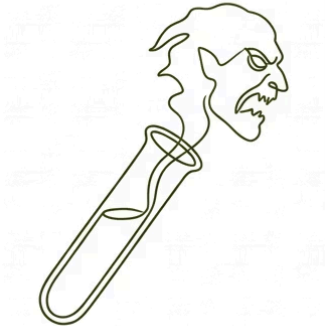
Jekyll's central thesis. The repetition of "truly" insists on the universality of human duality — this applies to all men, not just Jekyll.

4

"Slowly losing hold of my original and better self"

The gradual adverb "slowly" and verb "losing hold" suggest addiction — loss of control as a creeping, unstoppable process.

Using Context Effectively

DARWIN & REVOLUTION  REVOLUTION	REPRESSION & PRIVACY 	DUAL LONDON  WEST END VS. SOHO
STEVENSON & BRODIE 	SCIENTIFIC ANXIETY 	SIN VS. FREE WILL 

How to Use Context Well

Context should **illuminate** the quotation — not replace analysis. Use it as a lens, not a history lesson.

-   **Do say:** "This reflects Victorian anxieties about Darwinian regression, suggesting that..."
-  **Don't do:** Three sentences of historical background with no link to the quote.

Useful phrases: *"Stevenson's contemporary readers, familiar with X, would have understood this as..."* or *"This mirrors the wider Victorian concern with..."*



The Gothic Setting as Quotation

"London streets...like a district of some city in a nightmare"

Stevenson uses **pathetic fallacy** to externalise psychological corruption. The city's fog, labyrinthine streets, and darkness mirror Jekyll's fractured mind — the gothic setting is not just backdrop, it is *meaning*. Analyse how the simile "like a nightmare" collapses the boundary between the real and the psychological.

How to Write About Quotes — Structure and Phrasing

Embed Smoothly

Integrate quotes into your own sentences rather than dropping them in as isolated blocks.

Analytical Starters

"This suggests..." / "The verb choice connotes..." / "This could imply..." / "Stevenson positions the reader to..."

Context Links

"This reflects Victorian anxieties about..." / "A contemporary reader would have recognised..."

Avoid These

Feature-spotting with no effect. Plot retelling. Vague claims. Context bolted on as an afterthought.

Always link back to the essay question — whether the theme is duality, reputation, science vs morality, or repression.

Model Analytical Paragraph

"Man is not truly one, but truly two"

1

Point

Stevenson presents duality as a universal human condition, not a personal flaw.

2

Evidence + Analysis

The repetition of "truly" insists on certainty; the stark numerical contrast — "one" vs "two" — mirrors the binary of Jekyll and Hyde.

3

Context

Victorian readers familiar with Calvinist ideas of innate sin would recognise this as a theological provocation about human nature.

4

Link

This reinforces the novel's central theme: the dangerous self-deception of men who deny their darker impulses.

Common Pitfalls to Avoid

✗ Quoting too much, analysing too little

A long quotation is not a substitute for argument. Select short, precise evidence.

✗ Naming a device without effect

"Stevenson uses a metaphor here" — so what? Always explain the *impact* on the reader.

✗ Context as an afterthought

Weave context into analysis, not as a final disconnected paragraph tagged at the end.

✗ Ignoring narrative structure

The epistolary form, delayed revelation, and multiple narrators are all analytical opportunities — use them.

Revision Checklist

Before submitting any analytical response, run through this checklist:



Precise Quotation

Have I selected a short, specific, and relevant quotation — not a long block of text?



Word-Level Analysis

Have I zoomed in on specific word choices, their connotations, and their structural effects?



Natural Context

Have I woven in context purposefully to deepen analysis — not as a standalone history point?



Alternative Interpretation

Have I considered what else the quote might suggest — showing I can think flexibly about meaning?



Question Link

Have I explicitly connected my analysis back to the essay question or key theme?